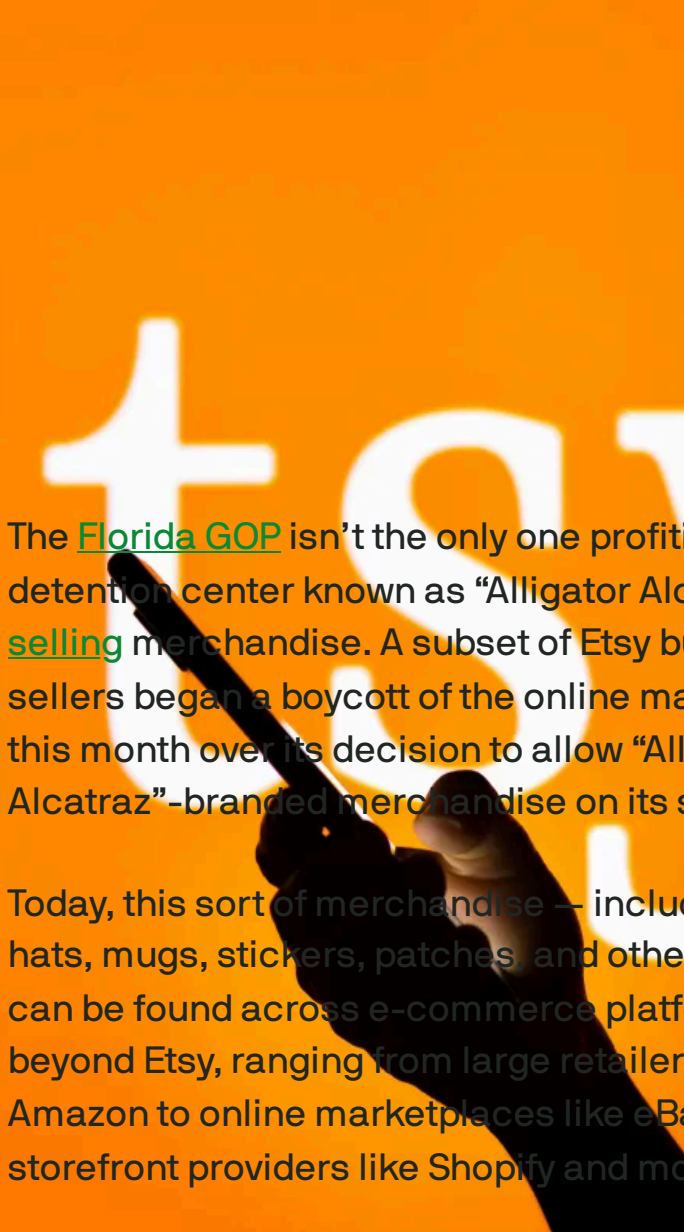


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COMMERCE



Etsy faces user boycott over 'Alligator Alcatraz'-branded products



The [Florida GOP](#) isn't the only one profiting from the detention center known as "Alligator Alcatraz" by [selling](#) merchandise. A subset of Etsy buyers and sellers began a boycott of the online marketplace this month over its decision to allow "Alligator Alcatraz"-branded merchandise on its site.

Today, this sort of merchandise — including T-shirts, hats, mugs, stickers, patches, and other items — can be found across e-commerce platforms beyond Etsy, ranging from large retailers like Amazon to online marketplaces like eBay to seller storefront providers like Shopify and more.

However, Etsy users have taken particular issue with the company's decision to allow the merchandise, which celebrates the controversial ICE detention center in Florida, where detainees are held in cages and subjected to reportedly horrible conditions, according to outlets like the [AP](#), [Newsweek](#), [The Washington Post](#), [CBS](#), [The NYT](#), [Tampa Bay Times](#), and others.

Etsy, its users argue, has a published [Discrimination and Hateful Content Policy](#), which lists "immigration status" as a protected class — meaning both behavior and merchandise cannot contain or display discriminatory behavior toward the listed protected classes. Boycotters believe that Etsy is in violation of its policy, as the company notes that prohibited behavior includes not only hate speech, but also "content which directly or indirectly

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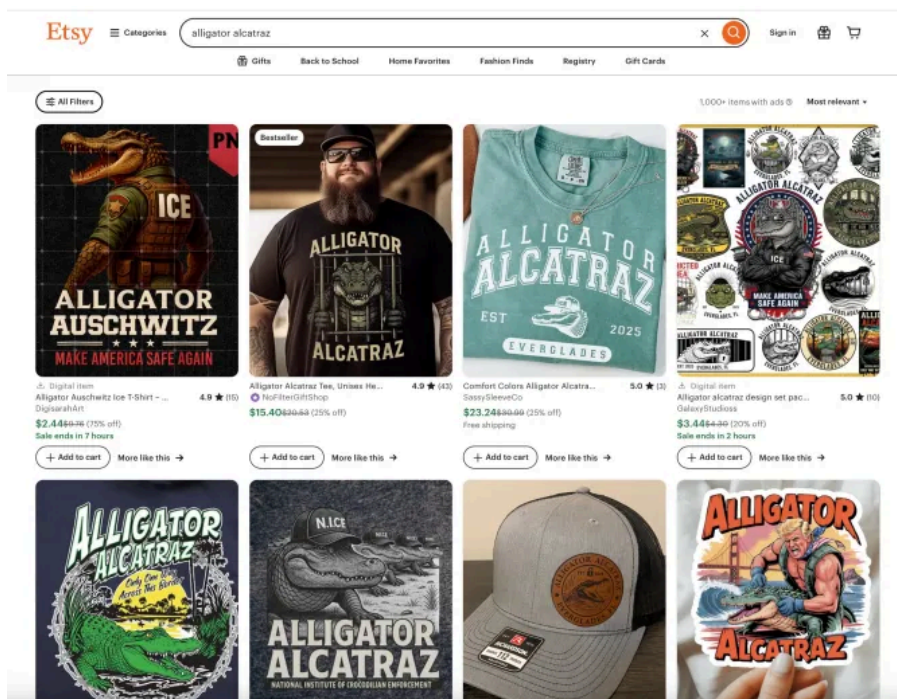
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contains violent or degrading commentary against protected classes listed above.”



ETSY’S SITE HAS 20 PAGES OF “ALLIGATOR ALCATRAZ”–BRANDED MERCHANDISE

IMAGE CREDITS:ETSY SCREENSHOT

The Etsy boycott has been loosely organized on social media platforms like Meta’s [Threads](#) and [Reddit](#) so far, where there are thousands of posts and comments. For example, [one Threads post](#) that references the boycott received more than 26,500 likes and a [Reddit post exclaiming “What are they thinking over at Etsy?!”](#) has 69,000 upvotes.

When searching for the term “[Boycott Etsy](#)” on Threads, you’ll find a long stream of posts debating the boycott, many of which have hundreds of replies. Some Etsy sellers worry their online businesses will suffer as a result, even though they are not selling this type of merchandise. Others, including those who disagree with the Trump administration’s policies, believe the merchandise is protected free speech.

On Reddit’s Etsy Community and elsewhere, [boycotting sellers](#) are [threatening to close their shops](#), and buyers say they’re [closing](#) their accounts. There are also references to the boycott

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across other social media sites like [X](#), [TikTok](#), [Facebook](#), and others.

Because the effort is so far only loosely organized, it's difficult to tell how many are participating. According to data from app intelligence provider Appfigures, Etsy's iOS app in the U.S. hasn't slipped in the ranks at this time — it's been in the top 20 apps in the Shopping category throughout the month.

Etsy is not alone in profiting from this type of merchandise, as some sellers and buyers have also pointed out. Many major selling platforms have not banned “Alligator Alcatraz”-branded products at this time. Among those TechCrunch reached out to, only Amazon was willing to defend its choice to host this merchandise, pointing us to its [policy around controversial products and content](#). The company also said the “Alligator Alcatraz” merchandise was compliant with its [guidelines](#).

Etsy did not respond to multiple requests for comment. eBay responded to an email request, but never shared a comment. Shopify didn't respond, nor did smaller platforms like Redbubble and TeePublic. (Walmart and Target were not found to be hosting this type of merchandise at this time. Walmart told TechCrunch it has clear guidelines around prohibited products, and those that don't comply are “promptly removed.”)

Etsy also featured a couple of sellers with pro-“Alligator Auschwitz” branded merchandise, among other listings for merchandise calling for its abolition (as seen in the screenshot below).

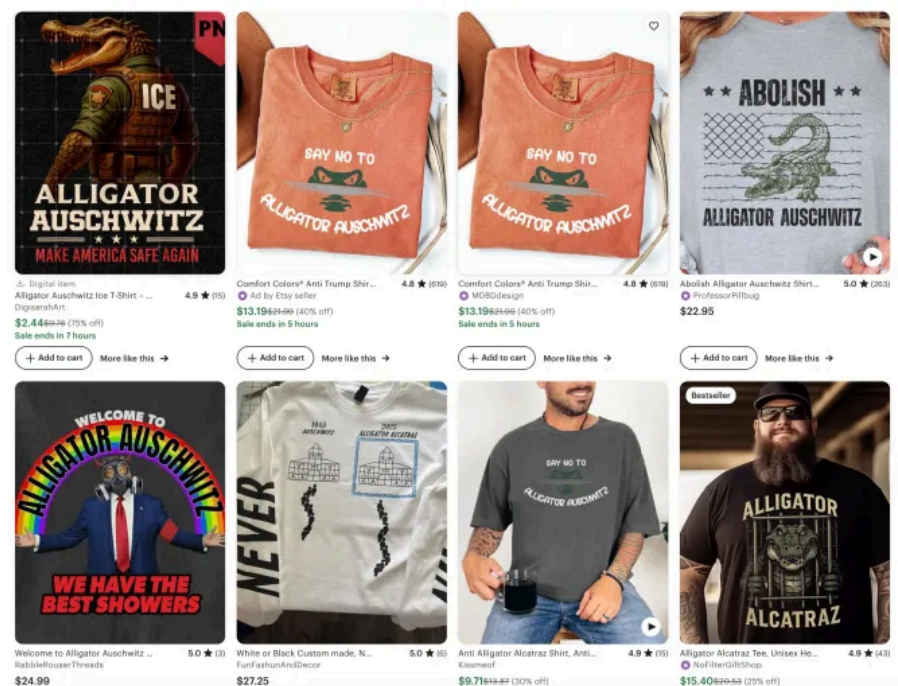


IMAGE CREDITS: ETSY SCREENSHOT

E-commerce platforms have weathered storms like this before, and have been known to host products that promote both right-wing and left-wing views without taking a political stance themselves.

But in more extreme cases, the companies have capitulated to customer backlash. For instance, [earlier this year](#), Shopify was caught hosting a storefront run by Kanye that was selling a swastika T-shirt and took it down, though it continued to host other stores that featured antisemitic content. [Amazon also previously faced backlash](#) over its decision to host right-wing militia merchandise and products celebrating QAnon conspiracies, and also [pulled](#) those [products down](#).

Topics: [Commerce](#) [eCommerce](#) [Etsy](#) [Politics](#)



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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...



IMAGE CREDITS: [THE_BURTONS](#) / GETTY IMAGES

COMMERCE



eBay and Etsy are relatively confident despite tariff pressures

Lauren Forristal — 8:00 AM PDT · May 3, 2025

Like virtually every sector in the business world, the secondhand industry is grappling with the ramifications of President Donald Trump's tariffs.

However, based on the comments made by eBay and Etsy earlier this week, both don't appear to be overly concerned.

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The companies recently reported Q1 2025 earnings results, both addressing the pressing topic of tariffs. eBay and Etsy are resilient to an extent, largely due to their sellers' approaches to sourcing products. In contrast to import-reliant rivals like Temu and Shein, [which recently raised prices in response to tariffs](#), many eBay and Etsy sellers in the U.S. mainly source their products locally, often selling used, vintage, or handmade items.

The companies provided data during their earnings

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Having sellers with local sourcing strategies can provide a significant advantage over competitors like Temu, Shein, and Amazon. However, secondhand companies still have to deal with the challenges that come with the ongoing economic uncertainty and consumer spending habits.

Etsy appears to be slightly more vulnerable when it comes to this. Etsy's core business model focuses on handcrafted and vintage goods, which tend to be priced higher. So, while Etsy sellers may not feel the effects of tariffs, customers are still hesitant to spend, leading to a 3.4% year-over-year decline in active buyers, bringing the total to 88.5 million. The number of habitual buyers was down 11%, totaling 6.2 million.

Additionally, Etsy reported an 8.9% decline in gross merchandise sales (GMS) for the marketplace to \$2.3 billion.

On a positive note, Etsy continues to benefit from its ownership of Depop, a secondhand fashion platform that remains popular amid the looming recession. Since acquiring Depop in 2021, the platform has achieved record-high GMS. The company didn't disclose specific figures.

“Etsy has a strong track record of navigating turbulent macroeconomic conditions, and we’re confident in our ability to keep adapting,” Silverman said.

In contrast, eBay is in a stronger position because more price-conscious shoppers are choosing used and refurbished goods, which the company said accounts for over 40% of its inventory. The company reported that customers eager to avoid tariffs have increased their spending, giving eBay a solid start to the quarter.

“We have observed healthy volume trends due to strength in our focus categories and what could be a modest pull forward of demand from consumers worried about increased costs and complexity at U.S. customs in the near future,” said eBay’s CFO, Steve Priest.

The company’s gross merchandise volume (GMV) grew to \$18.8 billion, while revenue increased over 1% to \$2.58 billion.

Topics: [Commerce](#) [eBay](#) [Etsy](#)

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Lauren Forristal

[X](#)

Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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APPS



Etsy begins rolling out visual search, starting with iOS users

Aisha Malik — 8:23 AM PDT · November 4, 2022

IMAGE CREDITS: [PAUL ZIMMERMAN](#) / GETTY IMAGES

Etsy is launching [a new image search feature](#) that is designed to help users find what they're looking for faster. Up until now, the only way to search on Etsy was through keywords. Now, users on iOS can tap the new camera icon in the search bar and upload or take a photo, after which Etsy will surface items that are visually similar to the image the user shared. Etsy says it plans to expand image search to Android app users soon.

The company says the new feature aims to help users discover items when they have trouble finding the right words to define a specific product. For example, say you're looking for a mug in your

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Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

favorite color, but don't know how to describe the exact shade you want. Or, you see a unique piece of furniture and want to find a small business that can hand-make something similar for you. The new image search feature should help you find what you're looking for in instances like these.

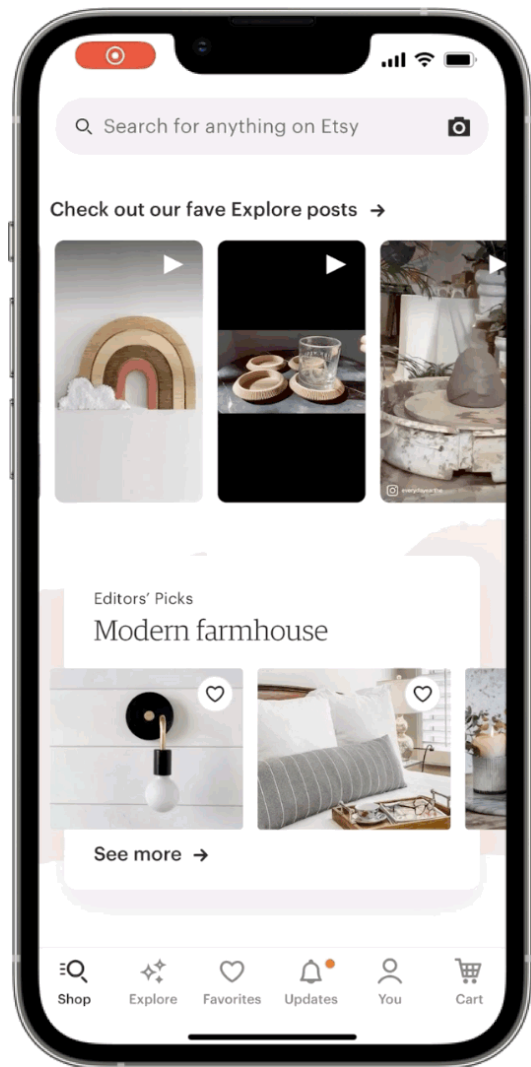


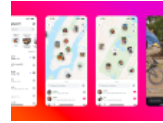
IMAGE CREDITS: ETSY

“With more than 100 million items in our marketplace, odds are that if you can dream it — or snap a photo of it — you’ll find something you love on Etsy,” the company said in a [blog post](#). “We’re always investing in our marketplace to make it easier for sellers to grow their businesses. We’re excited for this new, innovative feature to make it easier for sellers to get discovered and connect with our built-in base of nearly 90 million buyers around the world.”

Etsy says the new feature was developed as part of CodeMosaic, which is an annual Etsy Hackathon

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

APPS



Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 19 hours ago

that gives engineers opportunities to try out new skills while building creative solutions.

The launch of Etsy’s new feature comes as platforms like Google and Pinterest have had image search capabilities for quite some time now. Google recently added updates to [its multisearch feature](#) that lets users combine a photo and text to craft custom searches, initially around shopping. The search giant also [added its Lens image search](#) right into its home page this week, letting users access the advanced image recognition tool directly from the search box.

Etsy released its [third-quarter earnings](#) on Wednesday and reported a revenue bump of 11.7% over the same quarter of 2021, to \$594.5 million. The bump was likely partially due to the platform’s increased transaction fee from 5% to 6.5%. The change saw sellers [go on strike](#) earlier this year after the fee increase was announced. Etsy had noted on its website that the increased fee supported its plans to make “significant investments in marketing, seller tools and creating a world-class customer experience.”

[Etsy is launching a purchase protection program, investing \\$25M to cover refunds in some cases](#)

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporter...

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